

WFSC 140 Wildlife at the Movies

Film Review (10 points)

Example

Finding Nemo - Just Keep Swimming Until You Find Yourself

Ah, Pixar. The studio that single-handedly turned children's entertainment into a genre that makes grown adults sob into their popcorn while simultaneously wondering, "How did we get here?" And now, with *Finding Nemo*, the latest fish tale from their increasingly life-affirming assembly line, Andrew Stanton reels us in with a story about courage, parenthood, and the delicate balance between letting go and hanging on for dear life.

Finding Nemo opens with Marlin (voiced by the Woody Allen mimic, Albert Brooks), an anxious clownfish with parenting instincts that put helicopter moms to shame. The reason? A tragedy so heavy it might make Sophocles blush: his entire family, save for one little egg (soon-to-be-Nemo), is devoured by a marauding barracuda. Cue Marlin's obsessive, suffocating love for his remaining son, Nemo (voiced by the devilishly defiant Alexander Gould), whose desire for independence inevitably lands him in the crosshairs of every parent's worst fear—he gets lost. And not just wandering around the mall lost, but kidnapped by a scuba diver and taken halfway across the ocean to a fish tank in Sydney lost.

At its heart, *Finding Nemo* is a classic father-son odyssey, one as ancient as time itself. You might even picture Homer putting down his lyre to nod approvingly. Marlin, our hero, teams up with the delightful, forgetful Dory (Ellen DeGeneres at her comedic best), a blue tang who embodies the ultimate, albeit well-meaning, distraction. Their journey is filled with adventure, including encounters with surfer-dude turtles, reformed vegetarian sharks, and a flock of seagulls whose entire vocabulary consists of the word "mine." Yet, beneath the colorful coral and bubbly humor lies something deeper: a commentary on adulting, anxiety, and the unique terror of watching yourself or someone you love swim out into the world.

As Marlin and Dory navigate the ocean's perils, Stanton and Pixar's team ensure that our emotions remain as turbulent as the waters the characters traverse. The animation, as par for the course, is a visual feast—the shimmering ocean depths are so beautifully rendered, they make you want to book a snorkeling trip (minus the barracudas). Every ripple, every ray of light feels alive, further immersing us in this aquatic odyssey.

The magic of *Finding Nemo* is how it toes the line between sentiment and humor. Albert Brooks delivers a performance that is both poignantly tragic and comically anxious, a Alvy Singer clownfish, if you will. Meanwhile, DeGeneres's Dory steals every scene, her

forgetfulness not merely a running gag but a poignant reminder of the importance of living in the moment. We laugh at her short-term memory loss, **but we also envy her carefree existence and ability to do right by her friends**. Who wouldn't want to let go of their burdens, if only for a moment, and just keep swimming?

In the grand tradition of family films that appeal to adults and children alike, *Finding Nemo* taps into universal fears—loss, grief, the uncontrollable nature of life. Marlin's growth as a father, learning to trust the world and his son, is as satisfying as any character arc you'll find. And yes, the tear ducts will be tested so bring your kleenex. Don't be surprised if you find yourself choking up as the credits roll as you wonder why **a movie about talking fish has made you question every adult decision you've ever made or will make.**

In the end, *Finding Nemo* reminds us that the ocean—much like life—is vast, unpredictable, and often terrifying. But with **a little help from your forgetful friends**, you just might **make it through fins flying**.

Final verdict? **Grab some popcorn, settle in like your favorite anemone and be enchanted.** Because in a world that often feels as chaotic as the deep blue sea, sometimes you just have to remember: *just keep swimming*.

GenAI Citation

ChatGPT <https://openai.com> (accessed 2024-10-10) prompt: Please create a 1 page film review for a public audience of the film Finding Nemo made in 2002 directed by Andrew Stanton. It should be in the voice of film critic Molly Haskell of the Village Voice

Reflection

In this review of *Finding Nemo*, I thought chatGPT did a good job with structure, style, and voice. It produced a first draft that included humor, some emotional insight, cultural commentary and a mostly complete review aligning with the voice of Molly Haskell. However, whatever writing it trained on seemed to be heavy with adjectives and adverbs. I spent much time removing them in my edits. Also, I tried to add more emotional depth to the review with connections to New York City (where the *Village Voice* circulates primarily) and expand on the feminist bent of Molly's typical review style. I need to spend more time on replicating Molly's personal anecdotes, she is famous for those highly personal tidbits to share an aspect of her personality with the readers and form trust with them. Next time, I could also attach more film reviews from the current *Village Voice* to the GenAI query to help GenAI create something more recent. I am not as familiar with what the audience expects from their film reviews right now in that publication. Overall, this is a solid draft to send to a hypothetical editor for further suggestions and revisions on my part.